

Microsoft 365 Exchange Distribution Lists

This document builds on the Microsoft 365 Exchange Online Essentials Guide and focuses on Distribution Lists, with emphasis on importing and exporting Dynamic Distribution List (DDL) members using Exchange Online PowerShell.

Distribution Lists enable a single email address to reach multiple recipients. Exchange Online supports two types:

- **Static Distribution Lists:** Members are managed manually and are best for fixed or small groups.
- **Dynamic Distribution Lists:** Membership is calculated at send time based on attributes such as department, title, or location, eliminating manual maintenance.

Key insight: Dynamic Distribution Lists do not store static members. Membership is evaluated when an email is sent, which reduces administrative effort, but limits visibility in the Microsoft 365 admin center.

Importing Users into a Dynamic Distribution Group

Important: You cannot directly import users into a Dynamic Distribution Group (DDG). Instead, you assign attributes to users and configure the DDG to include users based on those attributes.

1. Install and Connect to Exchange Online

```
Install-Module ExchangeOnlineManagement -RequiredVersion  
Import-Module ExchangeOnlineManagement  
Connect-ExchangeOnline -UserPrincipalName admin@yourdomain.com
```

Use this PowerShell Command if your script requires version 3.5.0

```
Install-Module ExchangeOnlineManagement -RequiredVersion 3.5.0 – Force - AllowClobber
```

2. Prepare CSV File

Sample CSV file (users.csv)

```
UserPrincipalName,CustomAttribute1  
user1@company.com,ProjectA  
user2@company.com,ProjectA  
user3@company.com,ProjectA
```

3. Import Users and Set Attributes (PowerShell)

```
$users = Import-Csv "C:\scripts\users.csv"  
  
foreach ($user in $users) {  
    Set-Mailbox -Identity $user.UserPrincipalName -CustomAttribute1 $user.CustomAttribute1  
}
```

4. Create Dynamic Distribution Group

```
New-DynamicDistributionGroup `  
-Name "ProjectA Users" `  
-RecipientFilter {(RecipientType -eq 'UserMailbox') -and (CustomAttribute1 -eq 'ProjectA')}
```

5. Verify Membership

```
Get-Recipient -RecipientPreviewFilter (Get-DynamicDistributionGroup "ProjectA Users").RecipientFilter
```

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Export Dynamic Distribution List Members

Dynamic Distribution Lists do not expose member lists in the Microsoft 365 admin portal. PowerShell must be used to preview and export effective membership. Open PowerShell as admin.

1. Install and Connect to Exchange Online

```
Install-Module ExchangeOnlineManagement
Import-Module ExchangeOnlineManagement
Connect-ExchangeOnline -UserPrincipalName admin@yourdomain.com
```

2. Retrieve the Dynamic Distribution List

```
Get-DynamicDistributionGroup "DDL - IT Department"
```

3. Export members of a Distribution Group to CSV

```
Get-DistributionGroupMember -Identity "AllStaff" |
Select FirstName, LastName, DisplayName, PrimarySmtpAddress |
Export-Csv "C:\Reports\AllStaff-Members.csv" -NoTypeInfo
```

Simplified Version

```
Get-DistributionGroupMember -Identity "AllStaff" |
Select DisplayName, PrimarySmtpAddress |
Export-Csv "C:\Reports\AllStaff-Members.csv" -NoTypeInfo
```

Important Considerations

- The export to a CSV file is a point-in-time snapshot
- Membership updates dynamically as user attributes change
- Only mail-enabled recipients are included
- PowerShell is the only supported method for exporting DDL membership

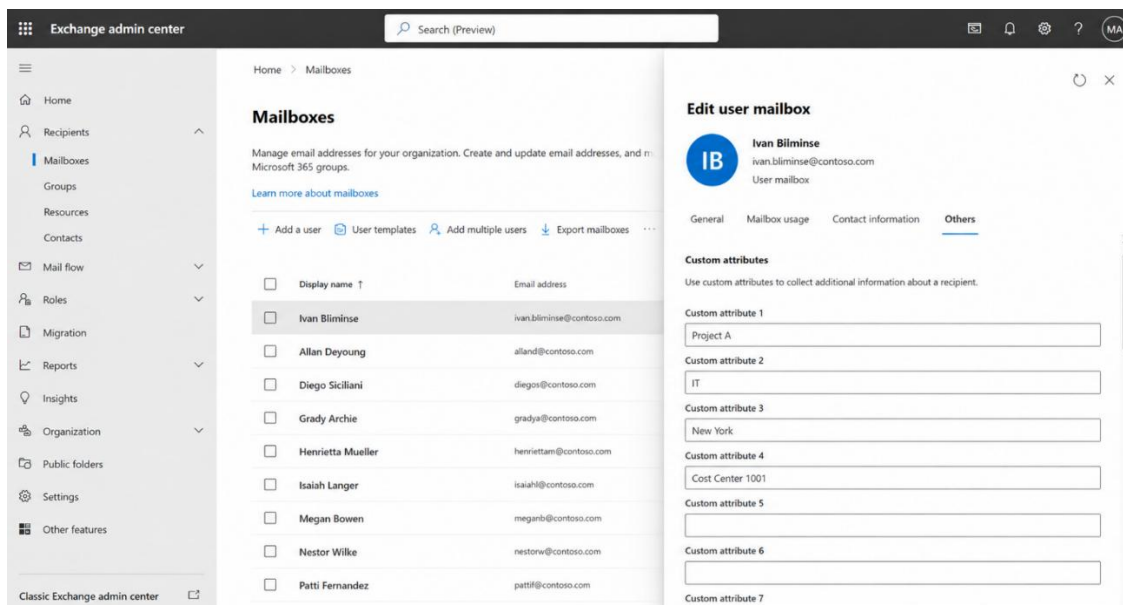
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How to edit a Custom Attribute

Applies to: CustomAttribute1–CustomAttribute15 (used for Dynamic Distribution Lists, reporting, filtering, etc.). These values are immediately usable in **Dynamic Distribution List recipient filters**.

Steps

1. Sign in to the **Exchange admin center** (<https://admin.exchange.microsoft.com>)
2. Go to **Recipients** → **Mailboxes**
3. Select the user mailbox you want to edit
4. Open the **Others** tab
5. Scroll to **Custom attributes**
6. Enter a value in **Custom attribute 1–15**
7. Click **Save**



PowerShell (alternative method)

Add Single User

```
Set-Mailbox user@domain.com -CustomAttribute1 "Project A"
```

One-liner pipeline PowerShell command for one or more identities

```
"user1@domain.com","user2@domain.com" |  
ForEach-Object { Set-Mailbox $_ -CustomAttribute1 "Project A" }
```

Remove (clear) a Custom Attribute

```
Set-Mailbox user@domain.com -CustomAttribute1 $null
```